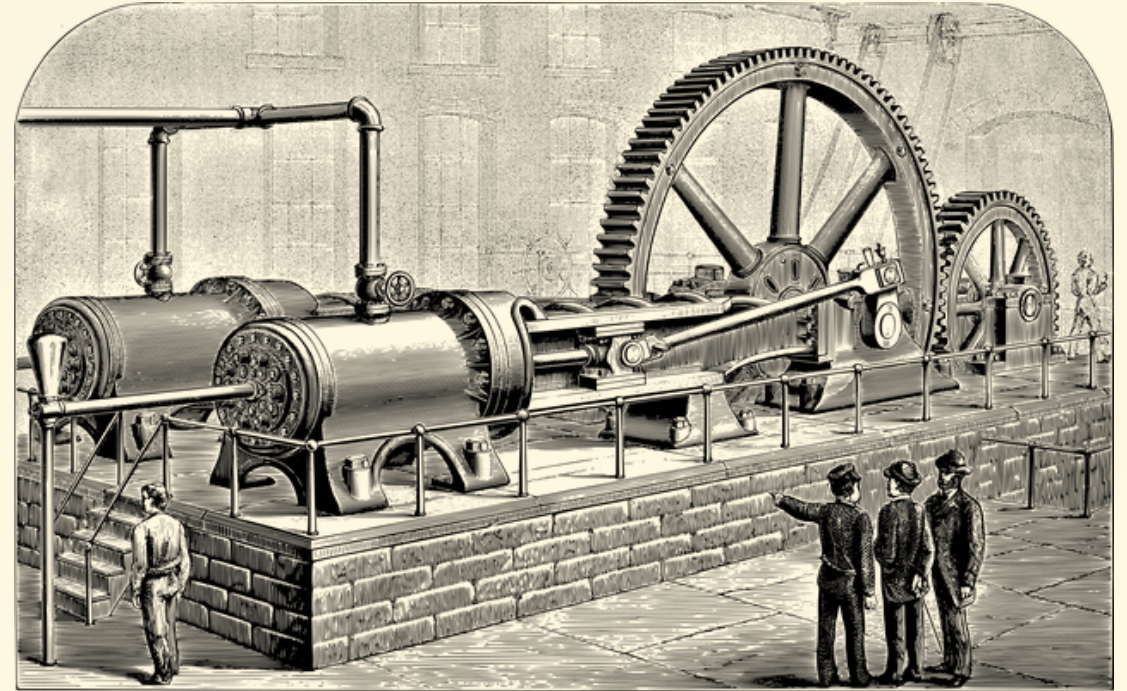


ECO 331

# Economic History

Introduction

Jonathan Conning  
Spring 2026



# Required Texts

- Koyama, Mark, Rubin, Jared, 2022. *How the World Became Rich: The Historical Origins of Economic Growth*. John Wiley & Sons.
- Galor, Oded, 2022. *The Journey of Humanity: The Origins of Wealth and Inequality*. Penguin.

Reasonably priced in e-book, print, and/or audio formats.

# Canvas LMS

[canvas.instructure.com/enroll/P9XDGD](https://canvas.instructure.com/enroll/P9XDGD)

- Syllabus, Reading Schedule
- Threaded Discussions
- Homework and grades
- free



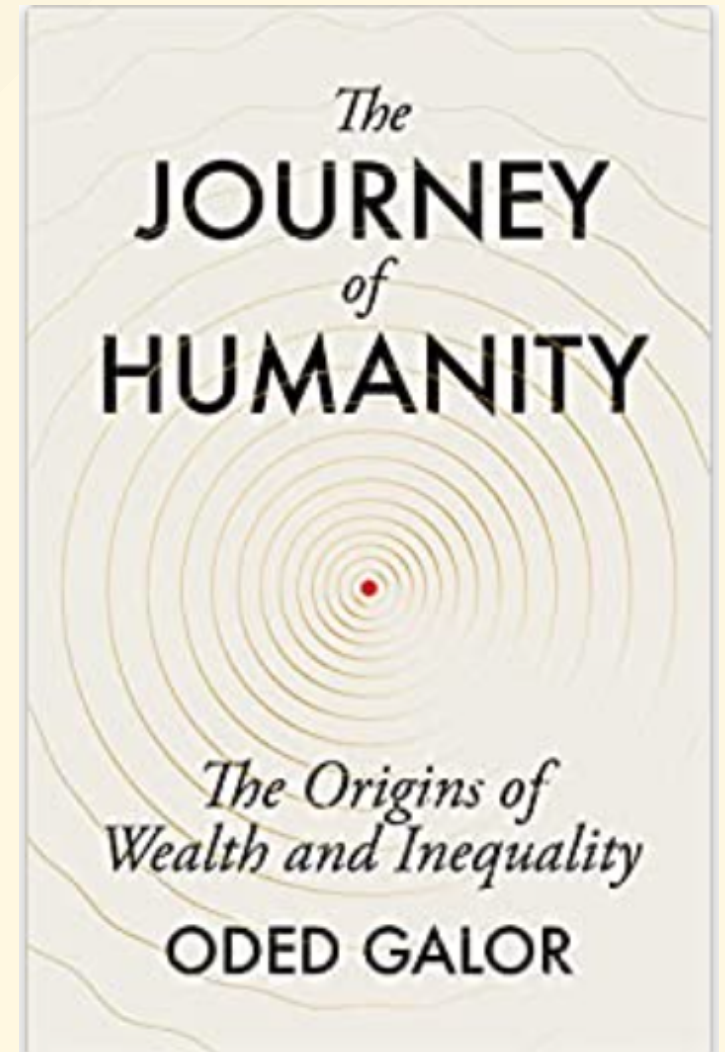
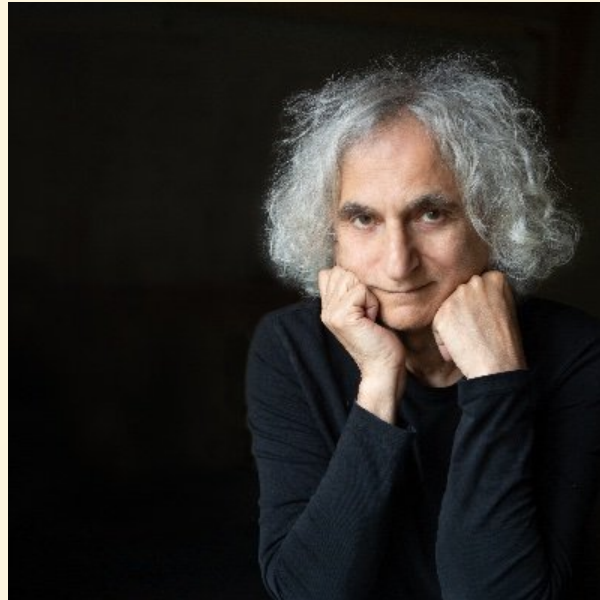
# Grading



| Activity                 | pct  |
|--------------------------|------|
| Discussion/Participation | 35 % |
| Midterm                  | 20 % |
| Article/Chapter Report   | 15 % |
| Final Exam               | 30 % |



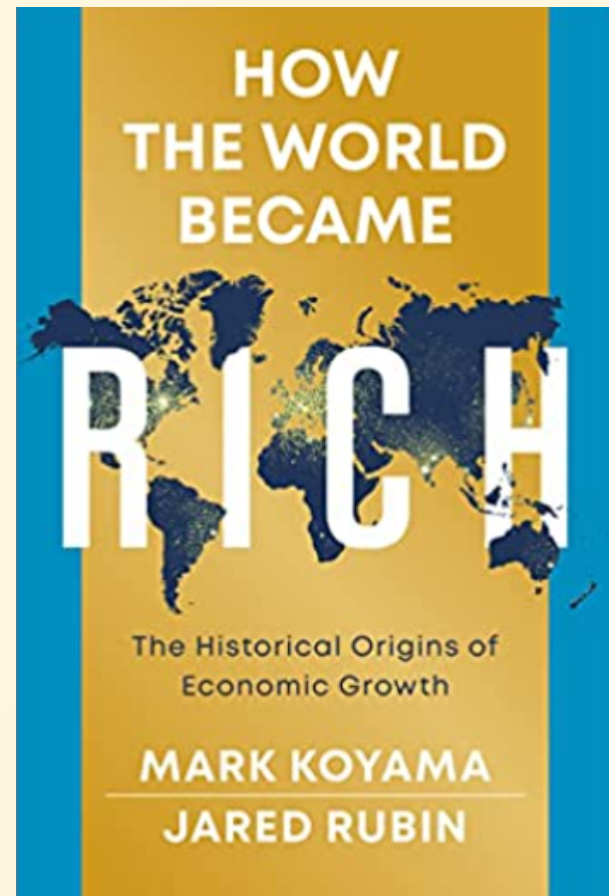
**Oded Galor**  
Brown University



# Unified Growth Theory

Oded Galor





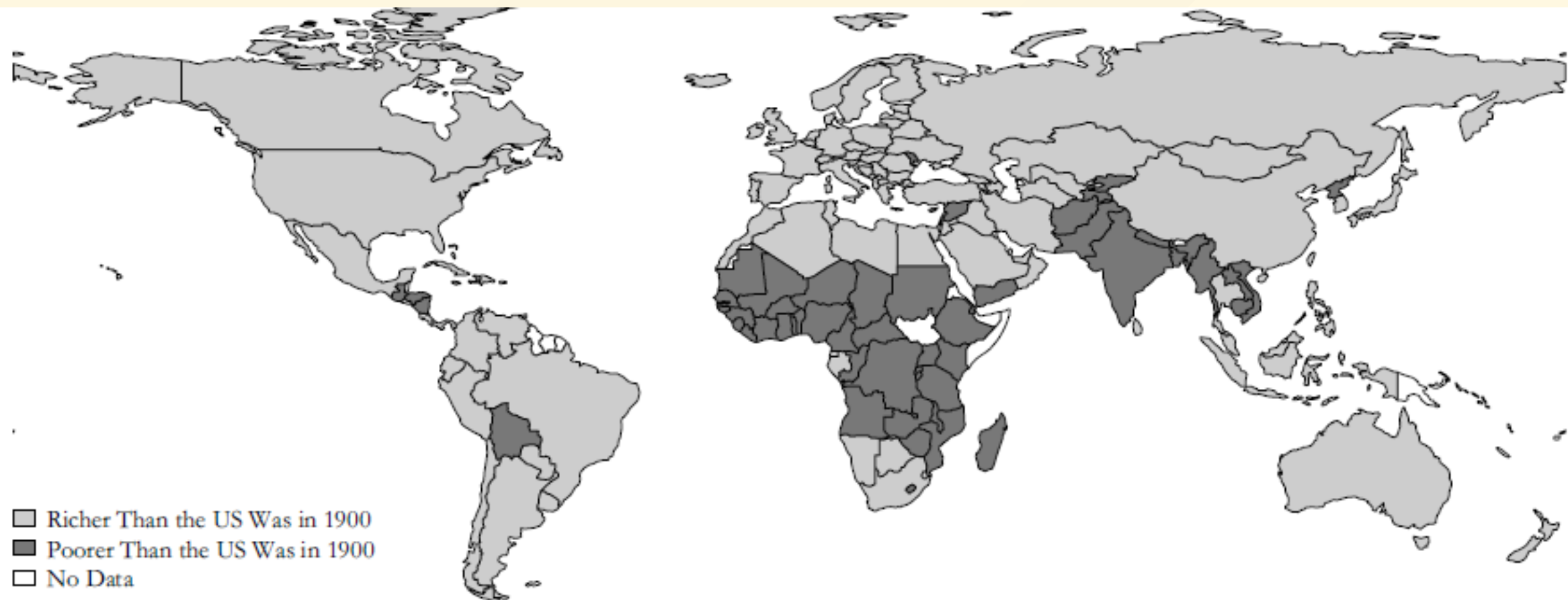
**Mark Koyama**  
(GWU)

**Jared Rubin**  
(Chapman  
Univ)

# 'Big History' Questions

- How did the world become Rich?
- Why did it take so long?
- Why did it happen first in some places before others?
- Why isn't the whole world rich?





**Figure 1.1** Countries that were richer in 2018 (annual per capita income) than the US in 1900  
*Data source:* Bolt and van Zanden (2020). Average income in the US in 1900 was \$8,970 in 2011 USD.

# Transitions

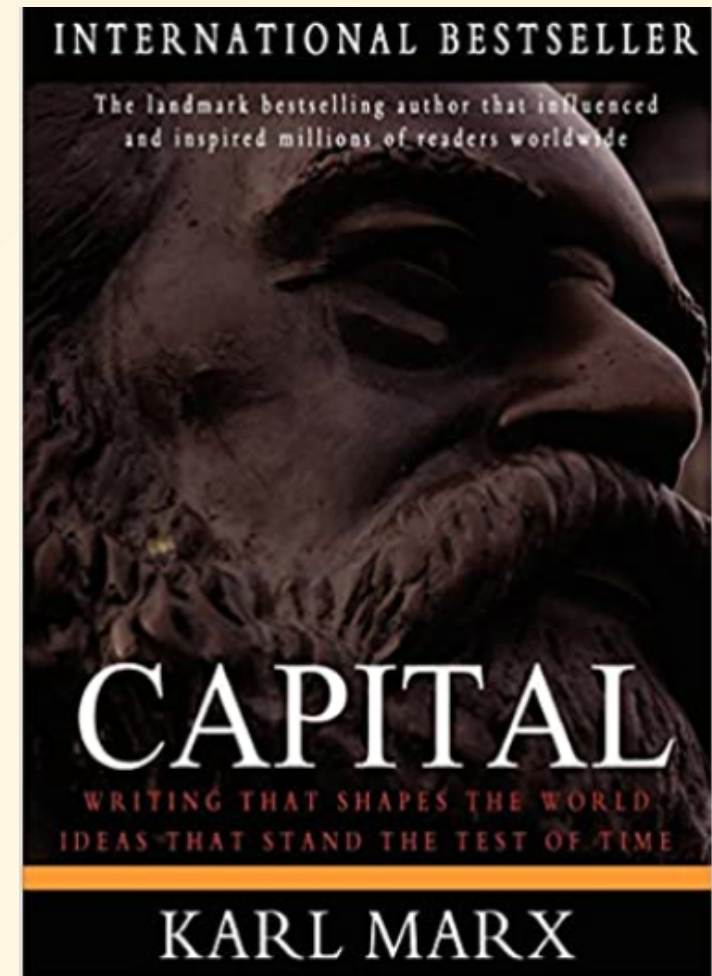
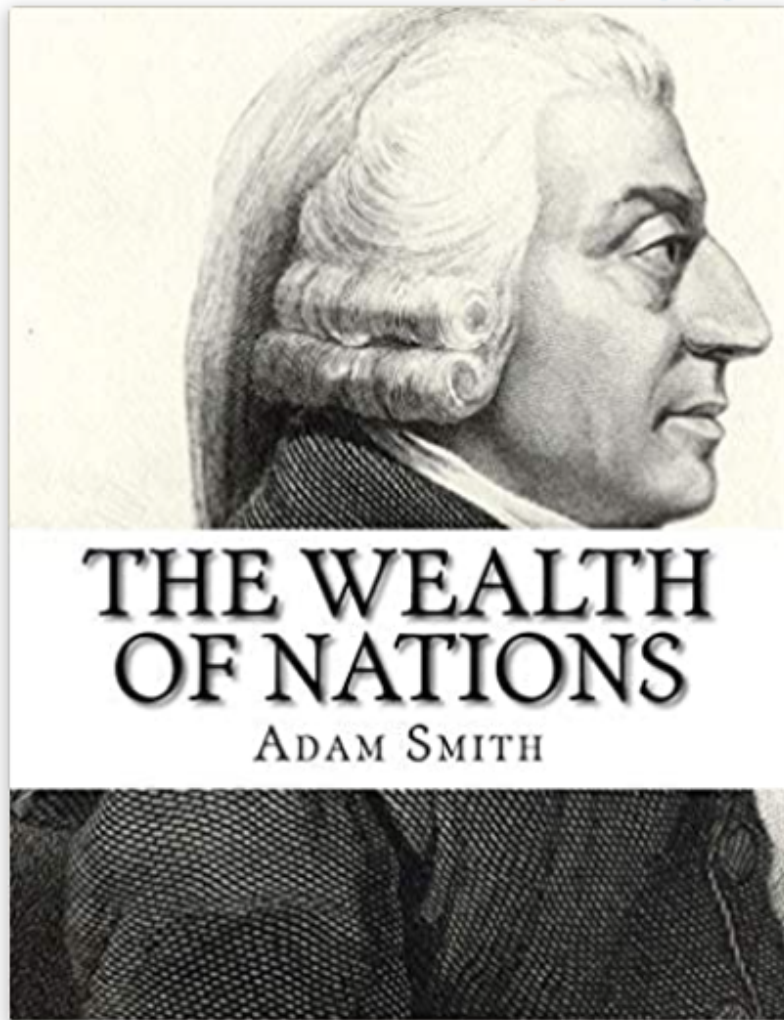
- The Neolithic Revolution
- Early States, Empires
- Malthusian Trap
- Rise and Fall of Feudalism

# Transitions (continued)

- Capitalist Transitions
  - The enclosure of lands
  - The rise of cities, Modern States
  - Demographic Transitions. Malthusian escape
- Conquest, Colonization, Slavery
- The Industrial Revolution(s)
  - Firms, Technology R&D
  - Global Trade and Finance



## Classical Political Economy





Barrington Moore, Jr.

# SOCIAL ORIGINS OF DICTATORSHIP AND DEMOCRACY

With a new Foreword by Edward Friedman and James C. Scott

LORD AND PEASANT  
IN THE MAKING OF  
THE MODERN WORLD

"A profoundly important book."

- New York Times Book Review

WINNER OF THE PULITZER PRIZE

A MAJOR  
PBS  
SPECIAL

# GUNS, GERMS, AND STEEL

*The FATES of HUMAN SOCIETIES*

JARED DIAMOND

WITH A NEW AFTERWORD

# THE GREAT

# DIVERGENCE,

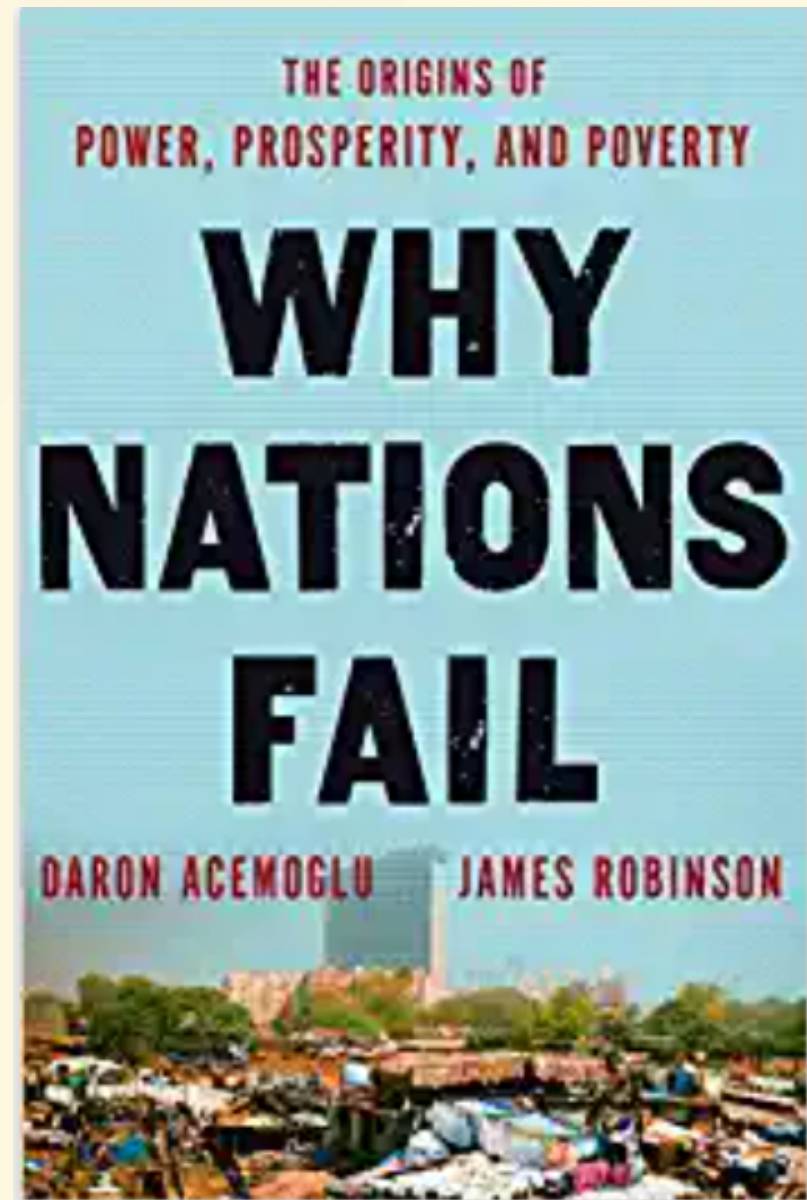
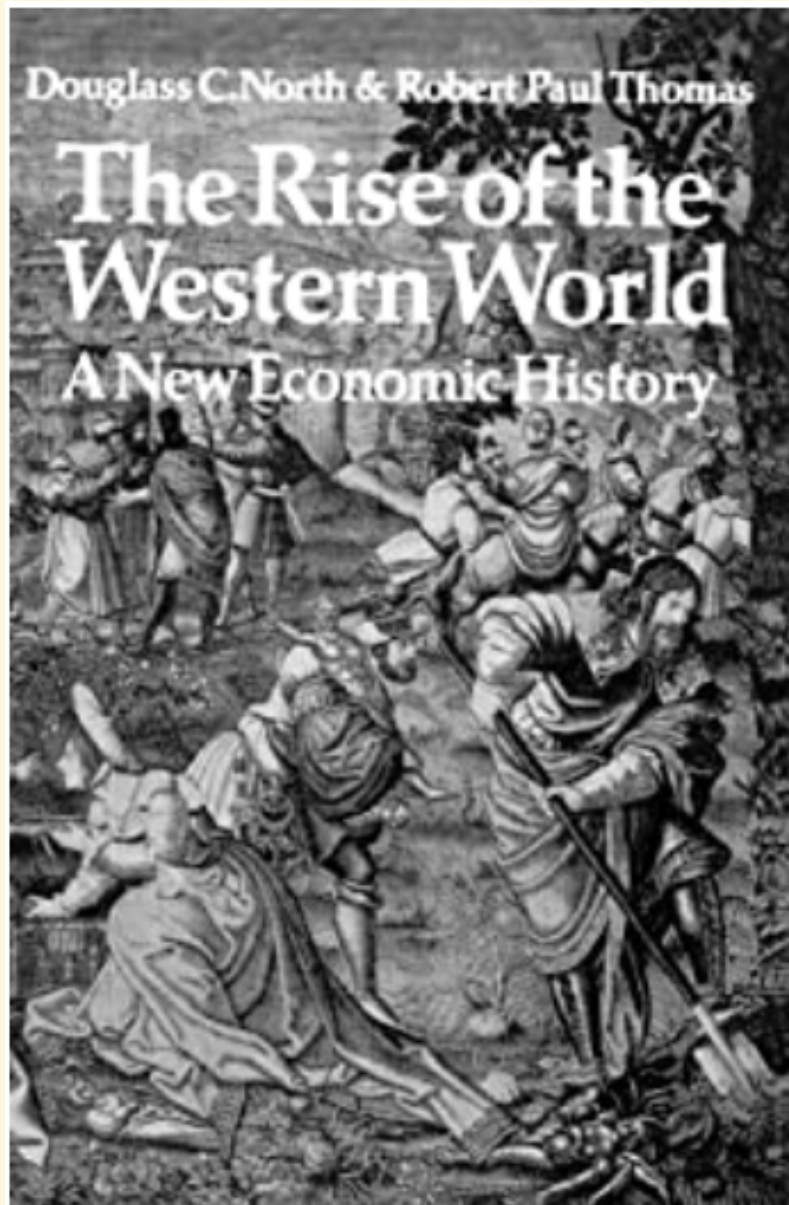
CHINA, EUROPE, AND THE MAKING OF  
THE MODERN WORLD ECONOMY



KENNETH POMERANZ

With a new preface by the author





## 2025 Nobel Prize in Economics



- Joel Mokyr: “for having identified the prerequisites for sustained growth through technological progress.”
- Aghion and Howitt: “for the theory of sustained growth through creative destruction.”



## 2024 Nobel Prize in Economics

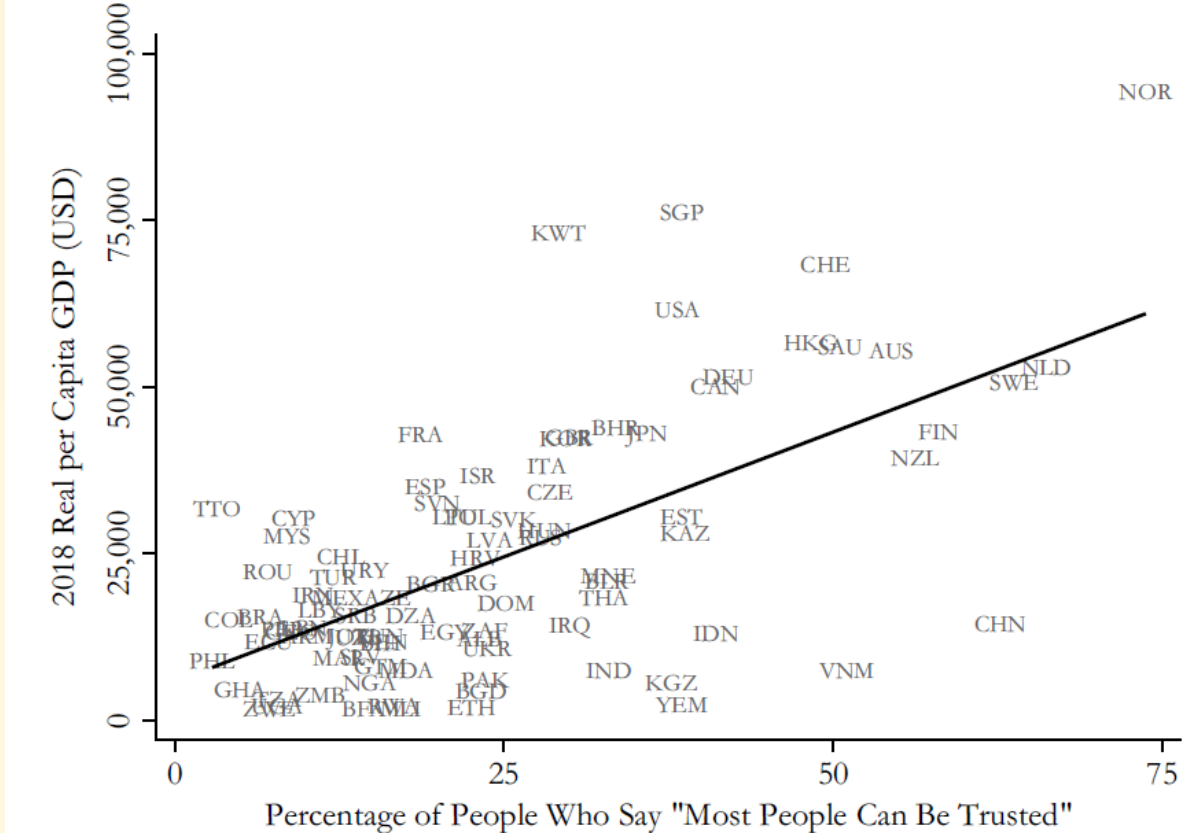
"for studies of how institutions are formed and affect prosperity"







- Proximate versus Fundamental Causes
- Causal Relationships vs. Correlations
- Exogenous vs Endogenous
- Can we identify causal relationships?



# KR's Explanation Categories

- Did Some Societies Win the Geography Lottery?
- Is it All Just Institutions?
- Did Culture Make Some Rich and Others Poor?
- Fewer Babies?
- Was it Just a Matter of Colonization and Exploitation?



# This Week

## Tuesday/Thursday: Introduction

- OG, "Mysteries of the Human Journey" (1-10)
- OG 1 "First Steps," (13-25).
- Henrich, Joseph (2017) "Chapter 1: A Puzzling Primate"
- KR 1, "Why, When, and How Did the World become rich" (1-16)

# Next and every week, due the night (8am) before class

- **Two questions**

- One factual/conceptual
- One probing, to take the conversation in interesting directions.

- **Two comments**

- Agree or disagree, reframe, etc.
- Historical observation or trivia

Submit via Canvas. Due 11pm the night before class.

- **Student Led presentations**

- Groups of 4. Responsible for short slide deck, typically on additional reading.



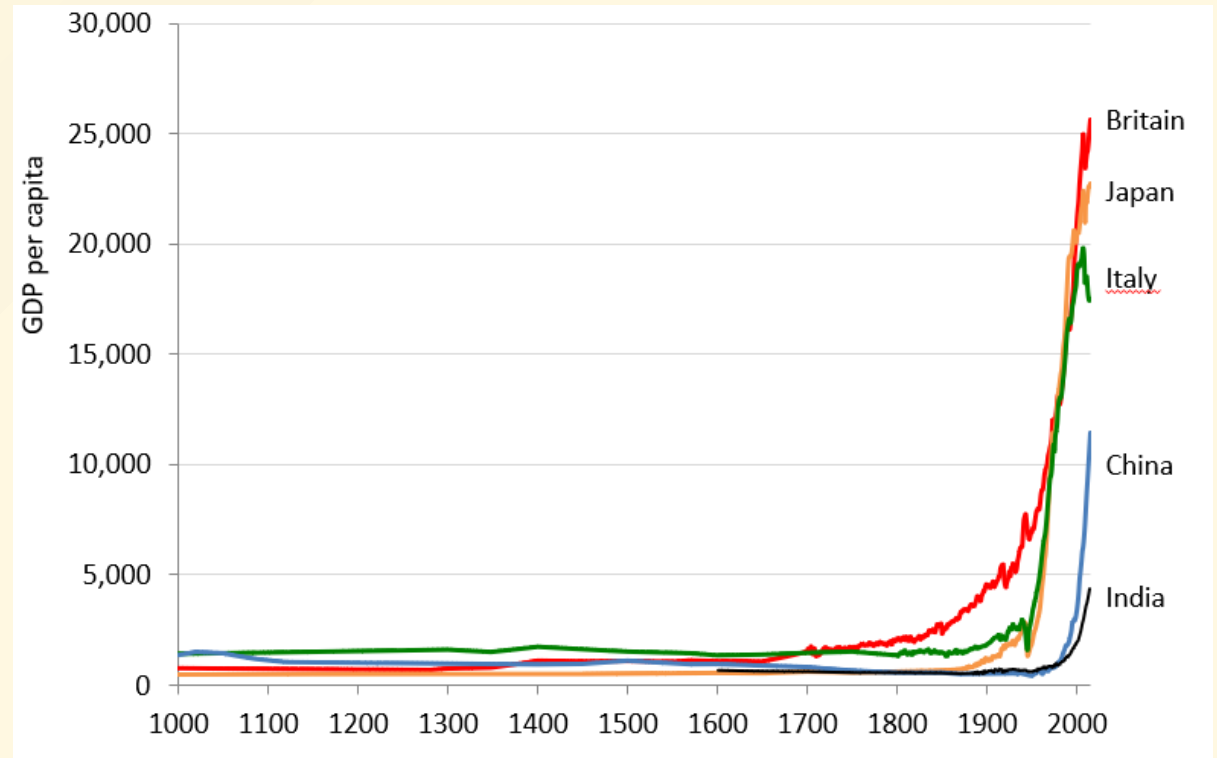
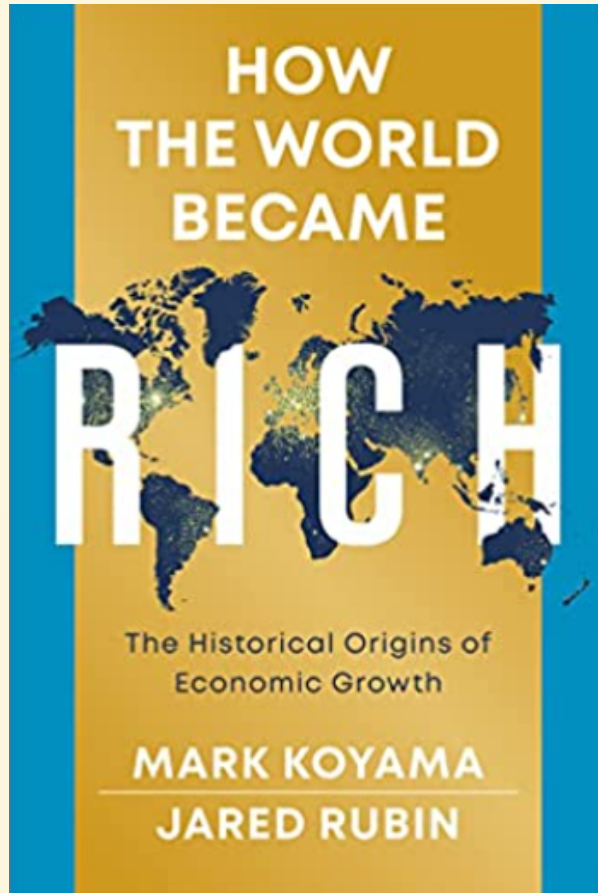
# Introductions

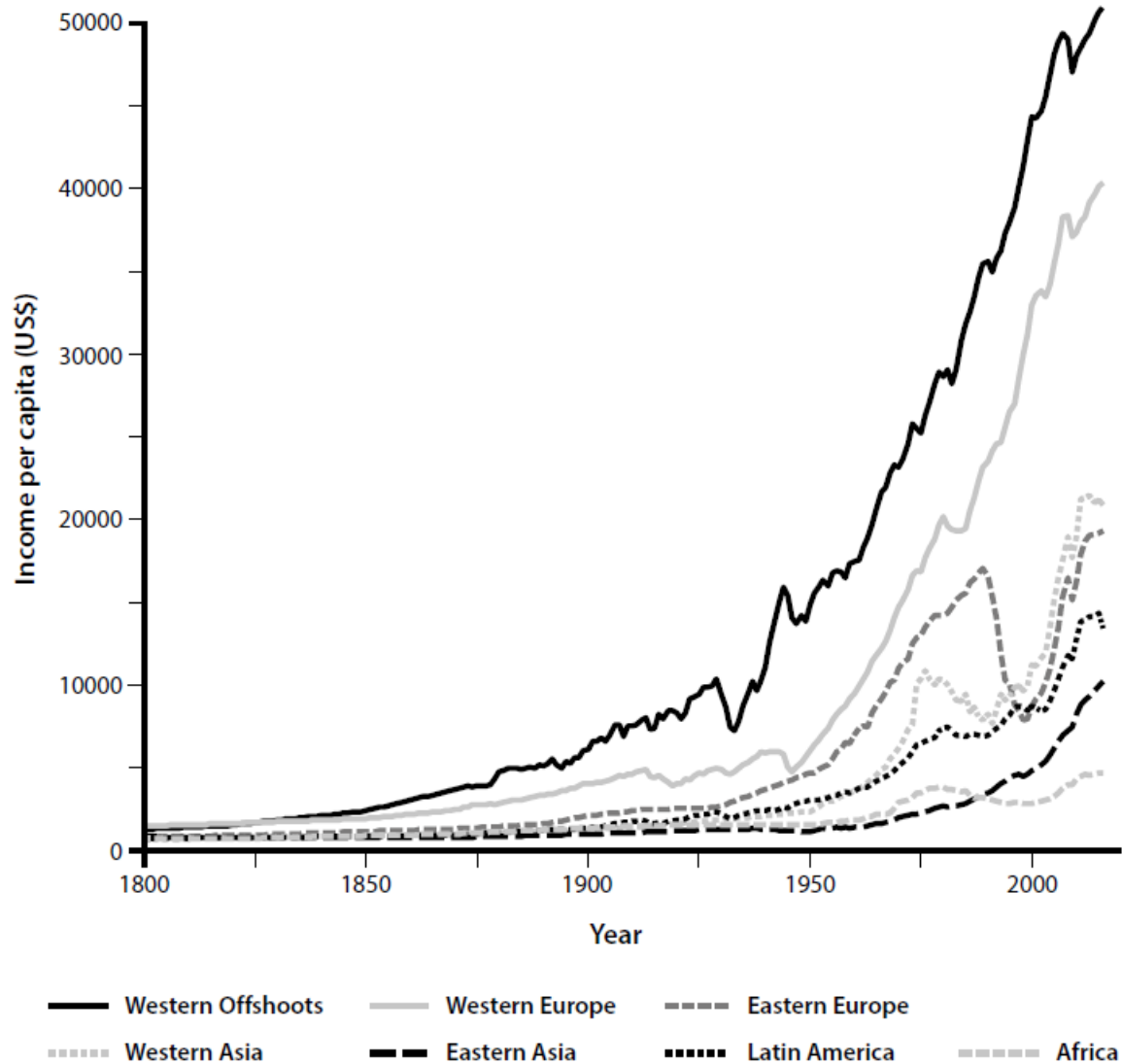
- Your name (nickname?)
- Major/minor
- Interests in economic history.
- Anything else interesting about yourself.

# Chapter 1

## Why, When, and How

## Did the World Become Rich?





**Figure 2. The Mystery of Inequality**

The divergence in per capita income across world regions in the past two centuries.<sup>7</sup>

- What does GDP measure?  
Same as income?
- Methods
  - GDP stats and deflators
  - PPP
  - Consumption baskets
  - Correlates
    - Height
    - Life Expectancy
- Are these the right measures?
  - what left out?

# Growth

- Does growth bring other values?
  - What other values?
  - Tradeoffs?
- Growth vs Development
- Sustained economic growth
  - Efflorescences
  - Shrinkages



# KR's list of theories

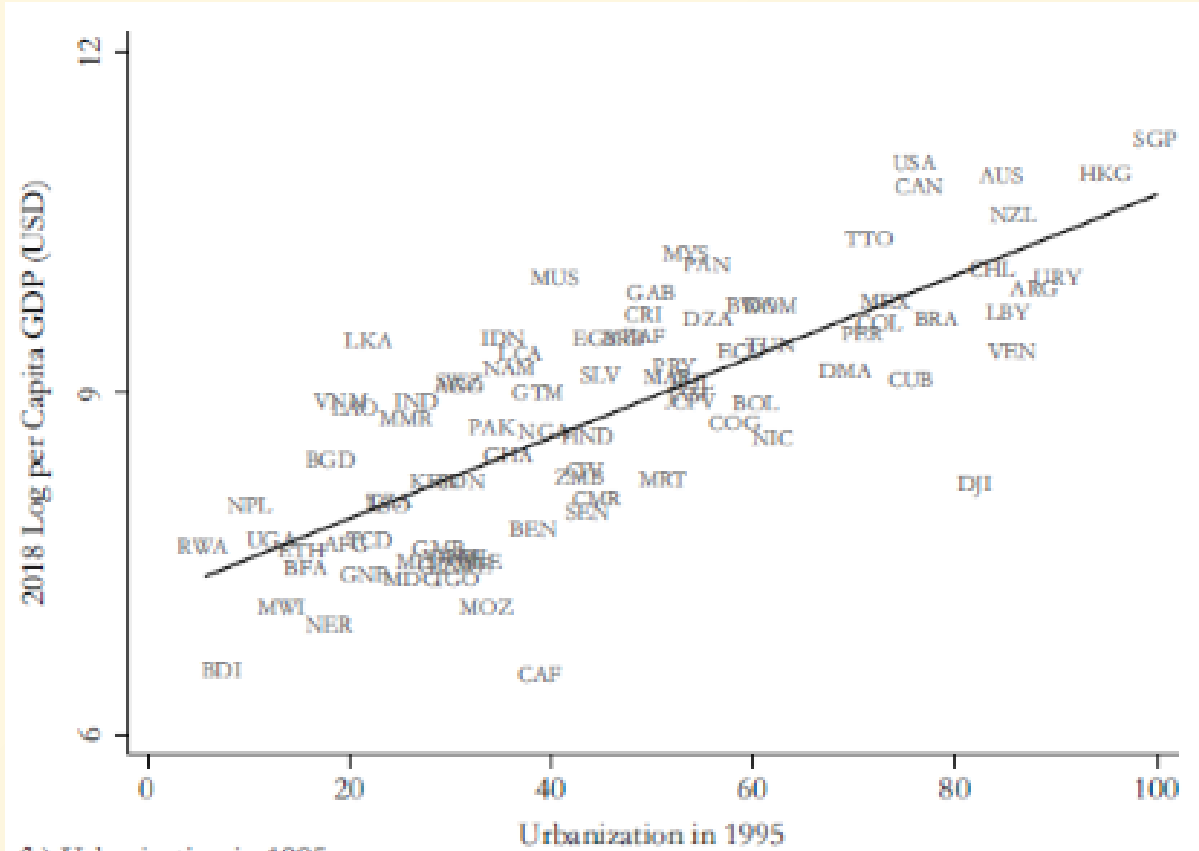
- Geography
- Institutions and Politics
- Culture
- Demographics
- Colonization and Exploitation

# Non-monocausal

# Contingent

Identification challenges

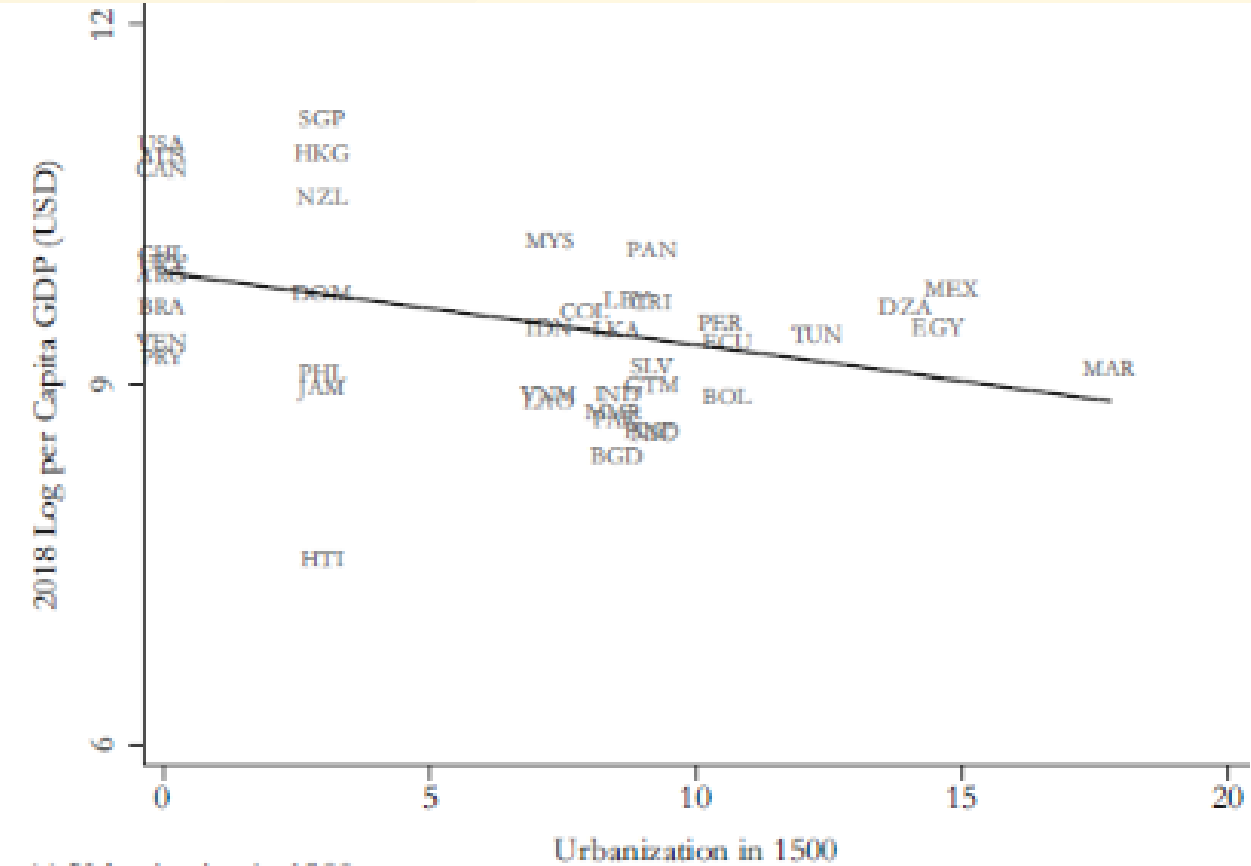




(b) Urbanization in 1995

**Figure 1.8** The reversal of fortunes within formerly colonized nations, 1500–1995

Data sources: Acemoglu, Johnson, and Robinson (2002) for urbanization, Bolt and van Zanden (2020) for GDP per capita.



(a) Urbanization in 1500



# What Makes Humans Different?

## A Puzzling Primate (Henrich)

- Physically weak, slow, poor climbers
- Any chimp can overpower us.
- Yet we spread to every terrestrial ecosystem on Earth
- From frozen Siberia to arid deserts to tropical rainforests

**The puzzle:** How did the world's most physically vulnerable primate become the most successful?

# Video Title

```
<iframe width="100%" height="600"  
src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/PNrWUS13th8" frameborder="0"  
allowfullscreen></iframe>
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# Culture: Our Secret Superpower

## Humans are a cultural species

- We learn from each other
- Knowledge accumulates across generations
- Skills improve and compound over time

Unlike other animals, humans can:

- Build on previous generations' discoveries
- Transmit complex knowledge through language
- Solve problems that no individual could figure out alone

**Culture makes us smart. We are not smart because our species is innately brilliant; we are smart because we have culturally evolved vast tools and knowledge.**

# Language & Symbolic Thought

## Language enables:

- Precise communication of complex ideas
- Storage of knowledge beyond individual memory
- Teaching of abstract concepts
- Cooperation at unprecedented scales

## Without language:

- Fire, cooking, tools would not accumulate
- Each generation would start from scratch
- We could not maintain the body of knowledge needed to survive new environments

**Language is uniquely human** - our capacity for grammar, symbols, and abstract thought sets us apart fundamentally from all other species.

# Tools, Technology & Cumulative Innovation

## From Henrich: Culture-Gene Coevolution

Humans have evolved the capacity to:

- Make and use increasingly complex tools
- Learn through demonstration and imitation
- Transmit technological knowledge intergenerationally

## Examples of cumulative cultural packages:

- Fire and cooking (requires knowledge transmission)
- Fishing nets and boats (requires multiple integrated skills)
- Shelters adapted to local environments
- Food preparation and preservation techniques
- Hunting strategies and weapons



# Global Expansion: A Recent Phenomenon

**Tens of thousands of years ago**, humans migrated across the globe:

- Crossed land bridges to Australia (40,000+ years ago)
- Reached the Arctic and subarctic (20,000+ years ago)
- Adapted to every major terrestrial ecosystem
- Developed specialized technologies for each environment

## **The Malthusian Reality:**

- For nearly 300,000 years, per capita income barely rose above subsistence
- Plagues and famines were abundant
- 25% of babies did not reach their first birthday
- Life expectancy rarely exceeded 40 years
- Population growth offset all technological gains